

 EMERGING TECH RESEARCH

Robotics & Physical AI VC Trends

VC activity across the robotics & physical AI ecosystem

Q1
2026





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Institutional Research Group



Ali Javaheri
Senior Research Analyst, Emerging Spaces
ali.javaheri@pitchbook.com

Caleb Wilkins
Data Analyst

pbinstitutionalresearch@pitchbook.com

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Robotics landscape

- 1 Industrial robotics
- 2 Logistics & warehousing
- 3 Medicine & healthcare
- 4 Agriculture & food
- 5 Consumer robotics
- 6 Defense & security
- 7 Hardware & components
- 8 Software & AI

For the complete Robotics taxonomy and company list, [click here](#) to see the market map on the PitchBook Platform.





Quarterly analysis

Key takeaways

Q1 2026 marked a structural break in robotics financing: Robotics & physical AI startups raised \$16.3 billion across 492 deals, the strongest single quarter on record by both measures, up 154% QoQ and 256% YoY. Three rounds (Shield AI at \$1.5 billion, Saronic at \$1.8 billion, Neura Robotics at \$1.8 billion) account for roughly \$5 billion of the value total. Strip those and the underlying quarter is approximately \$11.3 billion, still the highest ex-outlier figure in the dataset. However, the break is not the headline figure. It is that three independent shifts moved in the same direction at once: The US military institutionalized permanent marketplace procurement, the software layer repriced through market-clearing transactions, and the exit market opened for the first time.

The diligence filter tightened around two questions: scale and stickiness: For most of the 2021 to 2024 cycle, the question was whether the technology works. Q1 added a second test weighted about as heavily: Can the company build at volume, and does it hold a paying customer? RaaS contracts and repeat commercial orders are the signal. Viral demonstrations are not. Agility Robotics' Digit cleared more than 100,000 totes at GXO under a multiyear robotics-as-a-service contract, the clearest commercial deployment signal in the humanoid category globally, and Waymo reached 3,067 vehicles and approximately 500,000 paid rides per week across 10 cities. Against those benchmarks, more than 70% of Unitree's 2025 revenue came from research and education clients rather than factory operators, and NVIDIA acknowledges that its DreamZero model is not yet reliably deployable.

The robotics software layer repriced in a single quarter: Skild AI raised \$1.4 billion at a \$14 billion post-money valuation, backed by SoftBank and NVIDIA. Physical Intelligence was reported in active talks above \$11 billion, roughly double its Q4 2025 post-money valuation in four months.

AI & autonomy platforms reached \$5.3 billion TTM, up 431% YoY. The mechanism is integration cost. Hardware capability is no longer the binding constraint in deployment. Integration is and software that compresses it captures the margin. SoftBank paying approximately 2.3x revenue for ABB's robotics hardware division in the same period codified the inverse: Intelligence captures margin, hardware commoditizes.

US defense procurement moved from policy to infrastructure, but the budget headline did not follow:

In the span of a single week in late March, the Army launched an "Amazon-style" UAS Marketplace on March 24, opening with roughly 30 vetted systems and scaling to 70 or more. The Navy replaced its cancelled MASC program with a production-ready MUSV Marketplace on March 26, advancing seven vendors to prototyping against approximately \$2.1 billion in One Big Beautiful Bill Act funding. These mechanisms convert the traditional procurement valley of death into a recurring revenue pathway for vendors with domestic supply chains and demonstrated production lead times. They are operational today. The proposed \$54.6 billion fiscal year 2027 autonomy budget is not. Roughly 98% depends on a reconciliation bill that may not pass, and modeling returns on it without weighting enactment risk misprices the category.

Industrial robotics is on track to overtake defense as the top segment by capital deployed: Defense & security and industrial together captured roughly 62% of Q1 capital, and both now exceed \$10 billion TTM. Defense attracted \$4.5 billion in Q1 across 101 deals, reaching \$11.9 billion TTM, up 48% versus the prior TTM period. Industrial reached \$5.6 billion across 118 deals, \$10.8 billion TTM, up 83%, now within 10% of defense and growing faster on both value and count. If those growth differentials hold, industrial will displace defense in two to three quarters, carried by assembly & manufacturing robots at \$7.8 billion TTM, up 385% YoY.



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China leads on volume, the West on deployment proof: Asia represented 54% of Q1 deal count but only about 25% of deal value, an average deal size near \$15.3 million against \$72 million in North America. AgiBot shipped its 10,000th embodied robot in the quarter, and Unitree filed for a STAR Market IPO targeting roughly \$616 million with committed annual capacity of 75,000 humanoids. Western companies show deeper enterprise pull: Agility at GXO; Apptронik piloting with Mercedes-Benz, GXO, and Jabil; and Figure AI at a \$39 billion post-money valuation, the highest in the dataset. Which model captures long-term value is the central unresolved question for industrial robotics in 2026.

The exit market opened, and the broadening buyer base matters more than the headline value:

Exit value reached \$6.2 billion in Q1 2026 alone, more than the cumulative total of the preceding five years combined. Six public listings drove \$5.3 billion, led by Shenzhen Edge Medical (\$2 billion, surgical robotics), Huayan Robotics (\$979 million, assembly and manufacturing), Galaxis Technology (\$833 million, defense UAS), and Merlin Labs (\$800 million, defense UAS). The more durable signal is who is buying. The acquirer pool has moved well beyond defense primes into automotive (Mobileye), e-commerce (Amazon), warehouse automation (Symbotic), and infrastructure software (Bentley Systems). That broadening field of potential acquirers is the most consequential exit development of the quarter.

Venture-growth capital matched later-stage VC for the first time, signaling a pre-IPO cohort: Each stage reached \$5.9 billion in Q1 2026, and together they deployed 73% of total Q1 value, against \$3 billion combined in Q4 2025. The cohort behind the shift (Shield AI, Saronic, Apptронik, Zipline, and Neura Robotics) has crossed from R&D into production, holds government or commercial contracts, and is positioning for public markets. Venture-growth median pre-money valuation reached \$363 million in Q1, up from \$239 million for full-year 2025.

Logistics & warehousing reversed two years of decline, but one quarter is not a trend: The segment returned to 70% TTM-over-TTM growth on the strength of last-mile delivery, which reached \$1.3 billion TTM, up 140% YoY, while autonomous mobile robots and automated guided vehicles remain in value decline. Amazon acquired RIVR Technologies, and Symbotic acquired Fox Robotics in the same quarter, an early sign of strategic consolidation. The Federal Aviation Administration's targeted Part 108 BVLOS final rule is the regulatory unlock that could extend the recovery into inspection and commercial delivery through the second half of 2026 and into 2027.

VC activity

Robotics & physical AI startups raised \$16.3 billion across 492 deals in Q1 2026, the strongest single quarter on record by both measures. Deal value grew 154% QoQ and 256% YoY. Deal count rose nearly 10% from Q4 2025 and has increased in every quarter since Q1 2023. Three rounds—Shield AI at \$1.5 billion, Saronic at \$1.8 billion, and Neura Robotics at \$1.8 billion—account for roughly \$5 billion of the headline total. Strip those out and the underlying quarter is approximately \$11.3 billion, still the highest ex-outlier figure in the dataset and comfortably above the prior full-quarter record of \$9.8 billion set in Q2 2025. On a trailing-twelve-month (TTM) basis, deal value reached \$37.8 billion across 1,686 deals against a prior TTM of \$15.5 billion across 1,024 deals—value up 144%, count up 65%.

The stage mix is where the structural story lives. Pre-seed/seed delivered \$402 million across 113 deals—a record count, reversing the formation-stage compression that characterized 2023 and 2024. Early-stage VC delivered \$4 billion across 181 deals. Late-stage VC and venture growth each reached \$5.9 billion, the first time the two stages have matched in the dataset. Together they deployed \$11.8



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billion, or 73% of total Q1 value, against \$3 billion combined in Q4 2025. That shift in a single quarter is the clearest quantitative signal that a meaningful cohort of robotics companies has crossed from research & development (R&D) into pre-IPO positioning.

Valuations expanded sharply across every stage. Seed pre-money valuation reached \$43.2 million, up from \$13.4 million in full-year 2025—a threefold expansion at formation stage in a single quarter. Early-stage pre-money valuation reached \$61.4 million. Late-stage pre-money valuation reached \$126.7 million. Venture-growth pre-money valuation reached \$363 million, up from \$239 million in full-year 2025. Named deal step-ups confirm the directional move: Vatn Systems at 3.9x, Skild AI and Machina Labs each at 2.7x, Gecko Robotics at 2.4x, Shield AI at 2.2x, Mytra at 2.2x, Saronic at 1.9x. Capital is pricing ahead in subsegments with procurement or deployment validation, and the spread between those deals and the broader dataset is widening.

Defense & security led all segments at \$11.9 billion TTM, up 48% versus the prior TTM period, driven almost entirely by unmanned aerial systems at \$9 billion TTM and unmanned maritime systems at \$2.1 billion. Industrial robotics reached \$10.8 billion TTM—up 83%—closing within 10% of defense and growing faster on both value and count. If those growth differentials hold through Q2, industrial will displace defense as the top segment by capital deployed within two to three quarters. Robotics software & AI was the fastest-growing segment in relative terms at \$6.2 billion TTM, up 86%, carried by AI & autonomy platforms at \$5.3 billion TTM. Logistics & warehousing reversed two consecutive years of decline to post 70% TTM-over-TTM growth, although the recovery is concentrated almost entirely in last-mile delivery at \$1.3 billion TTM. Autonomous mobile robots and automated guided vehicles remain in value decline. Consumer robotics posted a 56% TTM-over-TTM decline, but the prior TTM was elevated by domestic service robot concentration unlikely to repeat; the contraction is a normalization, not a structural withdrawal.

Two subsegment patterns stand out beyond the segment headlines. Within industrial robotics, assembly & manufacturing robots account for \$7.8 billion of the segment's \$10.8 billion TTM, up 385% YoY. Material handling & palletizing reached \$1.4 billion TTM across just 12 deals—a 674% value increase on flat count growth—the data signature of investors writing larger checks into companies that have demonstrated manufacturing throughput rather than seeding new entrants. Within robotics hardware & components, end effectors & tooling grew 1,035% YoY to \$430 million TTM across 30 deals. Actuators & motion systems declined 19% in value despite deal count doubling, consistent with a fragmenting supply chain that has not yet produced category winners. Path planning & navigation—an established, commoditized software capability—grew only 7% in TTM value despite a 31% count increase, the clearest quantitative illustration of what the AI and autonomy platform repricing means in practice: Investors are sorting between software that enables current-generation robots to do known tasks and software that may generalize across unknown ones, and the pricing gap between the two categories is widening.

Physical AI themes

The software layer repriced: The clearest Q1 2026 valuation signal was not one round but two SoftBank transactions. SoftBank paid roughly 2.3x revenue for ABB's robotics hardware division—\$5.4 billion for a business generating \$2.3 billion in 2024 revenue—then co-led a round valuing Skild AI, a software-only platform with estimated revenue of about \$30 million, at \$14 billion. Hardware was priced like an industrial asset. Software was priced like an option on the future of robotics. The gap is increasingly visible in market pricing.



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That repricing extended beyond Skild. Physical Intelligence was in reported talks to raise roughly \$1 billion at a valuation above \$11 billion—nearly double its \$5.6 billion post-money valuation from four months earlier. AI & autonomy platforms reached \$5.3 billion in TTM deal value, up 431% YoY. Robot OS & middleware reached \$523 million TTM, up 328%. The full robotics software stack is being revalued.

The technology is not solved, though. NVIDIA's DreamZero World Action Model, published on arXiv in February 2026, posted more than 2x improvement in generalization to new tasks and environments compared to state-of-the-art vision-language-action models in real robot experiments.¹ NVIDIA's own GEAR Lab lead described it as not yet GPT-3 reliable. Skild AI's president has framed the core bottleneck as a data problem: There is no internet of robotics. Path planning & navigation rose just 7% in TTM deal value despite 31% deal-count growth, pointing to commoditization in parts of the stack. The software layer has repriced. It has not yet been won.

Orchestration and edge-AI gained validation: NODA AI's \$25 million Series A carried more signal than its size suggests. Booz Allen Ventures and Huntington Ingalls Industries participated alongside lead investor Bessemer Venture Partners, with both defense services primes described in the press release as strategic partners in delivery on Department of War customer milestones. NODA coordinates more than 30 OEM platforms across air, surface, subsurface, and ground domains and was selected to lead orchestration for a DoD multidomain collaborative autonomy program.²

Legion Intelligence's Centurion launch addressed the adjacent gap: autonomy that holds when connectivity fails. Centurion is an offline-first agentic edge-AI system rated IL2 through IL6, packaged as integrated hardware, software, and sustainment. NODA and Legion point to the same thesis. Scaled autonomy requires a cross-vendor cognitive layer that no single platform vendor will build alone.

Manufacturing capacity became a diligence priority: Anduril began Fury production at Arsenal-1 in late March, roughly three months ahead of the original July 2026 target.³ At full three-shift capacity the 22-station line can produce up to roughly 150 aircraft per year, per company officials quoted by Breaking Defense. Production had started—not merely been announced. In this sector, that distinction matters.

The same capacity lens ran through the quarter's largest rounds. Figure has described BotQ as moving toward an hourly robot production cadence. Saronic is building 300,000 square feet of fabrication space and planning Port Alpha at 10x current capacity.⁴ Neura Robotics expanded manufacturing across India and Hangzhou while securing Schaeffler as an actuator supplier.

Material handling & palletizing attracted \$1.4 billion in TTM deal value across 12 deals, up 674% on zero-count growth. End effectors & tooling rose 1,035% YoY. Investors appear to be paying increasingly for throughput, component reliability, and production readiness—not just prototypes.

China leads on volume; the West leads on deployment proof: China's humanoid ramp is unmatched on volume. AgiBot shipped its 10,000th embodied robot in Q1, scaling from 5,000 to 10,000 units in roughly three months.⁵ Unitree has filed for a STAR Market IPO targeting approximately \$616 million, although the company remains privately held pending completion of the listing process, with committed annual capacity of 75,000 humanoids and 115,000 quadrupeds. China's humanoid robot output is expected to grow by up to 94% in 2026, according to TrendForce.

That said, the customer mix is worth keeping in perspective. More than 70% of Unitree's humanoid revenue in the most recent filing period came from research and education buyers, not factory operators. Security concerns around Unitree platforms could further limit adoption in certain markets.⁶



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Western companies, by contrast, have stronger evidence of enterprise pull and deeper financing behind them. Agility's Digit cleared more than 100,000 totes at GXO Logistics' Flowery Branch, Georgia, facility under a multiyear robotics-as-a-service (RaaS) contract—the industry's first formal commercial and RaaS deployment of humanoid robots.⁷ Apptronik has active pilots with Mercedes-Benz, GXO, and Jabil. Figure AI carries a \$39 billion post-money valuation, the highest in the PitchBook robotics dataset.

Asia represented 54% of Q1 deal count but only about 25% of deal value—average deal size of approximately \$15.3 million versus \$72.0 million in North America. China appears to lead on humanoid unit volume and cost trajectory, while Western companies currently show more visible enterprise deployment proof. Which model captures long-term value remains the central question for industrial robotics in 2026.

Macro and industry backdrop

Labor scarcity and robot density are structural, not cyclical: Global robot density reached 162 robots per 10,000 employees in 2023, doubling over the prior seven years, per the International Federation of Robotics' (IFR's) World Robotics 2024 report.⁸ China ranks third globally at 470 robots per 10,000 workers; the US ranks tenth at 295.⁹ The demand-side pressures are unlikely to reverse quickly. Japan and South Korea face among the most severe demographic aging in the world. Germany's working-age population is projected to decline by roughly 4 million through 2035. In the US, interest in engineering programs from international students dropped 40% as of early 2025, compressing the talent pipeline at the moment deployment demand is expanding.

Commercial adoption data confirms the cycle is already running. Global professional service robot sales rose 30% in 2023 to more than 205,000 units, according to the IFR.¹⁰ Logistics robots drove more than half that total—roughly 113,000 units—followed by hospitality at roughly 54,000 and agriculture at roughly 20,000. Medical robot sales rose 36% YoY. These are deployed commercial systems, not venture-backed startups, and they confirm that automation adoption is broad and accelerating independent of the investment cycle.

The key point for investors is that this demand does not reset with the cycle. Demographic pressure does not ease in a downturn. MIT research by Acemoglu and Restrepo found that countries with rapidly aging populations invest disproportionately in manufacturing automation to sustain output regardless of macro conditions. This makes the category less dependent on the venture cycle alone.

Sovereign programs are channeling noncyclical capital into hardware: Governments are treating robotics hardware components—sensors, actuators, power systems—as strategic assets. China's Made in China 2025 initiative channels capital into intelligent robotics with explicit domestic-production targets. Japan, South Korea, Germany, and the EU continue to support robotics through national and regional industrial-policy programs spanning sensors, autonomous mobility, and secure local component ecosystems.

Hardware and component startups in lidar, 3D vision, tactile sensors, and high-precision motion systems may benefit from less cyclical sovereign demand. DJI restrictions and National Defense Authorization Act (NDAA) supply chain rules are strengthening the defensibility of domestic and allied drone and component suppliers. Reshoring is changing the unit economics of hardware startups with domestic production. Late-stage capital is flowing to platforms and integrators with strong upstream partnerships because sovereign investment may de-risk their scaling path.



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RaaS is expanding the addressable market beyond enterprise buyers: Traditional robotic deployments cost \$100,000 to \$500,000 upfront, locking out most small and mid-size businesses (SMBs). RaaS converts that capital expenditure into an operating expenditure. Collaborative robots priced at roughly \$10,000 to \$20,000 paired with subscription or leasing structures are pulling in SMB buyers across floor-cleaning, service robotics, and warehouse automation. Agility's GXO contract is the most visible enterprise-scale RaaS deployment, but the model's larger impact on the investment landscape is at the SMB tier, where it opens deal flow in categories previously inaccessible to startups.

Integration cost amplifies the opportunity. Integration can represent a large share of total robotics deployment cost, making software-led deployment tooling a key value lever. AI-driven integration tools—trained via simulation and human-video pretraining rather than manual programming—are projected to cut those costs materially. The binding constraint in robotics deployment is not hardware capability. It is integration cost. That is the structural tailwind behind the software-layer repricing.

Regulation is unlocking some markets and constraining others: The FAA's proposed Part 108 BVLOS rule—targeted for approximately mid-March 2026 after a 43-day government shutdown delayed publication—would convert per-flight waivers into a scalable performance-based framework with Remote ID, detect-and-avoid requirements, and Part 146 Automated Data Service Provider certification. For logistics, inspection, and commercial delivery operators, this would convert point deployments into scalable networks. Implementation would lag publication by six to 12 months, so the investment impact would land in H2 2026 and 2027 data. The regulatory unlock is in motion, but timing remains dependent on final-rule publication and implementation.

ISO 10218, the core robotics safety standard, is expanding from 115 pages to roughly 400 to cover autonomous mobile robots and humanoids. Legacy standards were designed for caged industrial robots. Companies that participate in standards-setting can design to the standard from the start rather than retrofit compliance—a growing strategic priority for startups and incumbents alike.

In Europe, the European Union Aviation Safety Agency is advancing U-space and SORA 2.5 with AI risk modules. Civil-drone regulatory harmonization is progressing. The gap is on the defense side: Eurocontrol and industry observers flag that Europe still lacks an integrated counter-UAS security architecture as incursions over airports and military sites increase. In China, HEIS 2026 establishes the first national humanoid and embodied intelligence standard system—the same state standards-and-policy scaffold Beijing used in EVs, solar, and 5G, now applied to robotics.

Cybersecurity and governance risks are underpriced: Mobile and humanoid robots are cyber-physical systems. Insecure sensors, wifi protocols, and cloud integrations create attack surfaces that legacy IT security frameworks were not built to handle. In hospitals, exploitation could expose patient data. In factories, compromised systems become vectors for operational disruption. Security researchers have flagged data-collection and backdoor concerns in Unitree platforms—a risk that could restrict allied government procurement and narrow the addressable market in ways unit-volume projections do not capture.

Reveal Technology's acquisition of Anomaly Six adds governance and privacy risk exposure, combining tactical mapping capabilities with location-intelligence capabilities that have previously drawn scrutiny. That profile could affect allied adoption and draw regulatory attention that current deal models may not have fully priced in.



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Waymo's disclosed roughly 1:43 remote-operator-to-vehicle ratio and unredacted NHTSA ADS crash reports documenting multiple low-speed teleoperator-involved incidents in Tesla's Austin robotaxi fleet keep remote-operation disclosure and autonomy safety in regulators' sights. These are not footnotes. They could shape the commercial deployment timeline for autonomy platforms broadly.

Deployment and demand signals

Defense procurement infrastructure became permanent: The most consequential structural change of the quarter was not a contract award but the institutionalization of standing procurement channels.

The Army launched its UAS Marketplace on March 24, opening with roughly 30 vetted Group 1 through Group 3 systems via Basic Ordering Agreements and a perpetual Commercial Solutions Opening, scalable to 70-plus systems and hundreds of companies over two years. Every vendor screens for NDAA and Blue UAS compliance and demonstrated production lead times. Program manager Col. Danielle Medaglia called it "a fundamental pivot in how we execute acquisition for uncrewed aircraft systems."¹¹ The model is explicitly based on Ukraine's DOT-Chain Defence platform, which had delivered 485,000 UAVs and other equipment through the first months of 2026 through a marketplace listing nearly 800 items from more than 200 Ukrainian manufacturers—with a Ministry of Defense target of routing 70% of all drone purchases through the platform. In the first 3.5 months of 2026 the system moved UAH 22.9 billion worth of equipment, compared with UAH 10.5 billion in the first six months of 2025. That compression rate is what the Army is importing.

Two days after the UAS Marketplace launch, the Navy replaced the cancelled MASC program with a production-ready MUSV Marketplace funded by approximately \$2.1 billion under the 2025 reconciliation law, commonly referred to as the One Big Beautiful Bill Act. No prototyping phase—vendors must

deliver 2,500 nm-range vessels with at-sea tests by the end of fiscal year 2026 and deliveries in fiscal year 2027. PEO RAS Rebecca Gassler confirmed the construct will be reused across the complete family of all unmanned surface vessels.

The DAWG's proposed \$54.6 billion fiscal year 2027 autonomy R&D request—up from \$225.9 million in fiscal year 2026 and not yet appropriated, with roughly \$53.6 billion dependent on a reconciliation bill—is a demand signal, not a bankable number. The marketplace mechanisms are operational today. The budget headline is not.

Darkhive shows what the funded pipeline looks like when it works: a \$49.7 million APFIT award for Real-Time C2 at the Tactical Edge, immediately followed by a \$30 million Series B led by RTX Ventures. NDAA-compliant, production-proven, prime-backed. That sequencing is what the Army marketplace is designed to replicate at scale.

Field deployments validated autonomous systems in live operations: Ukraine's Brave1 ecosystem, now encompassing more than 300 ground-robot companies, is the largest live-fire autonomous systems development environment in the world. In Q1 the country committed to 25,000 UGVs for frontline logistics, double the prior year's target—the procurement infrastructure to fulfill that commitment is the DOT-Chain platform described above.

African Lion 26 took that operational experience into NATO formation doctrine. Running from April 20 to May 8 across sites in Morocco, Ghana, Senegal, and Tunisia with more than 5,600 personnel from over 40 nations, the exercise embedded more than 40 technology vendors with US forces to test battlefield systems across mission command, deep attack, and counter-attack integration. The 173rd Airborne Brigade conducted autonomous tactical vehicle training at Cap Draa on April 30—UGVs and



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UAS deployed for route clearance, reconnaissance, and logistics support. The inaugural multinational drone academics graduated service members from Morocco, Ghana, Nigeria, and the US. This moved beyond a standalone technology demonstration and into alliance-level formation training.

Waymo reached approximately 500,000 paid rides per week across 10 cities from a fleet of roughly 3,000 vehicles—a tenfold increase from May 2024—with the company targeting more than 1 million weekly rides by year-end after quadrupling trip volume in 2025.¹² Co-CEO Tekedra Mawakana called 2026 “an inflection point.” The utilization efficiency is the more telling number: The same fleet size that produced 50,000 rides per week in 2024 now produces 500,000, suggesting Waymo is scaling primarily through software and operational optimization rather than fleet expansion. Agility’s Digit cleared more than 100,000 totes at GXO under a multiyear RaaS contract—the current benchmark for commercial humanoid deployment globally.

Maritime autonomy confirmed as a production-scale category: Allied procurement moved in parallel with Saronic’s fundraise. Australia ordered 40 Bluebottle USVs from Ocious and Thales at A\$176 million for ASW and ISR, expanding its fleet to 55 vessels. The UK funded Kraken Technologies at £12.3 million for 20 modular USVs under Project Beehive, with a Kraken-Rheinmetall Naval joint venture established for European production under a NATO framework. Japan acquired 20 Wave Glider USVs via FMS at \$25 million. IAI delivered a BlueWhale containerized autonomous submarine to the German Navy for multiweek ASW and covert operations missions. Ukraine and the UK signed a joint production agreement on ocean-going naval drones anchored to a KyivAI Centre of Excellence. China ran an L30 USV swarm operational test off Zhuhai—AI-coordinated autonomous patrol and intercept with dozens of 7.5-meter craft. Coastal sea denial via autonomous surface platforms is doctrine, not experiment.

Strategic partnerships confirmed the orchestration layer: Booz Allen expanded its autonomy-focused venture fund to \$300 million and invested in NODA AI alongside Bessemer. Huntington Ingalls made a separate strategic investment in the same company the same quarter. The two largest US defense services firms independently backing the same orchestration platform in a single quarter suggests cross-vendor autonomy coordination has moved from concept to prime-level procurement requirement. The SoftBank acquisition of ABB’s robotics hardware division at roughly 2.3x revenue, set against its co-lead on Skild AI at a \$14 billion post-money valuation, produced the quarter’s sharpest hardware-to-software value migration signal—two transactions by the same investor that together price the structural shift more clearly than any analyst note could.

Exits

Q1 2026 produced 18 robotics & physical AI exits worth \$6.2 billion, a single quarter that exceeded the entire 2019 to 2025 cumulative total of roughly \$0.6 billion. Six public listings drove about \$5.3 billion, 11 acquisitions added roughly \$929 million in disclosed value, and one buyout rounded out the count.

The listings split two ways. Two were large Chinese industrial and medical names: Shenzhen Edge Medical at \$2 billion in surgical robotics, the quarter’s largest exit, and Huayan Robotics at \$979 million in assembly and manufacturing. Three were defense UAS names: Galaxis Technology at \$833 million, Merlin Labs at \$800 million through a business combination with Inflection Point Acquisition Corp. IV, and Swarmer at \$47 million. The sixth, Isvision Technology, listed at \$603 million in sensors and vision systems. The defense UAS listings are the first real public-market tests of government-contract-backed autonomy valuations, and the near-IPO defense pipeline now looks deeper than prior data



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implied. Merlin offers an early caution. The stock fell sharply on its first trading day, a sign that public markets price this category with more skepticism than late-stage private rounds do. Isvision's listing is the first large hardware and components public exit in the dataset, opening a new category of robotics infrastructure companies reaching public scale.

Mobileye's purchase of Mentee Robotics was the disclosed-value outlier at \$900 million, about \$612 million in cash plus Mobileye Class A stock, announced at CES in January and closed in early February. Automotive-adjacent autonomy companies are buying humanoid capability rather than building it. Serve Robotics acquired Diligent Robotics, maker of the Moxi hospital delivery robot, for \$29 million in stock plus a potential earn-out, a cross-segment move worth watching as a sidewalk delivery company extends into indoor mobile manipulation on a shared autonomy stack. The rest were undisclosed-price tuck-ins: RIVR Technologies to Amazon, Fox Robotics to Symbotic, Roboteam to Ondas, Canvas to JLG Industries, Pointivo to Bentley Systems, MAVRIK to HavocAI, SEQSENSE to Iris Ohyama, Scythe Robotics to Autonomous Solutions, and Zelostech to Cainiao. ARLANE and Dessintey took Axinesis private. Amazon and Symbotic each acquired warehouse or last-mile assets in the same quarter, which reads as deliberate platform-building.

Acquisition volume has climbed sharply. The sector recorded six transactions in 2024 and 23 in 2025, the highest annual count on record at \$54.4 million in disclosed value. Q1 2026 added 14 transactions at \$946 million in disclosed value, almost all of it Mentee. Most other deals carried no disclosed price, so count tracks the trend better than value, and the trend is up. The more durable shift is in who is buying. The acquirer pool has moved well beyond defense primes to automotive (Mobileye), e-commerce (Amazon), warehouse automation (Symbotic), consumer robotics (Autonomous

Solutions), and infrastructure software (Bentley Systems), each folding autonomy, perception, and automation into an existing platform rather than building from scratch. That broadening buyer base is the most consequential exit development of the quarter. It widens the field of potential acquirers well beyond the handful of defense and industrial names that historically defined the exit landscape.

Conclusions

Q1 2026 was a structural break, not a continuation: Three shifts moved in the same direction in a single quarter, and each would have mattered on its own. The US military institutionalized permanent marketplace procurement for autonomous systems in the span of a week, turning a persistent valley-of-death problem into a credible recurring revenue path. The software layer repriced through market-clearing transactions: Skild AI at \$14 billion, Physical Intelligence in reported talks above \$11 billion, and SoftBank's roughly 2.3x revenue payment for ABB's hardware division in the same window, which fixed how value is splitting between software and hardware. And the exit market opened for the first time, with \$6.2 billion in Q1 against roughly \$0.6 billion across the prior five years combined, including six public listings that set the sector's first real IPO benchmarks. None of this showed up in the prior quarterly data. The [Q4 2025 report](#) called the sector "moving decisively from experimentation toward large-scale deployment." Q1 2026 is that movement reaching the capital markets.

The diligence filter has tightened around two questions now, not one. For most of the 2021 to 2024 cycle the question was whether the technology works. Q1 points to a second filter weighted about equally beside it: Can the company build at volume, and does it have a paying customer? The largest Q1 rounds—Shield AI, Saronic, Apptронik, Neura Robotics, Hadrian, Zipline—answer both.



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They have crossed from R&D into production and hold government or commercial contracts. The companies that have not—most humanoid platforms outside Agility, most early-stage UAS names outside the marketplace-vetted cohort—are raising at earlier stages and smaller checks, or not at all. The barbell is widening.

Three things remain unresolved. Humanoid commercialization is the first. 2026 is the year that starts separating companies with durable factory revenue from those running staged demonstrations on research-client income. Agility's GXO benchmark is set, and the open question is how many others meet it by year-end. Those that cannot will face a harder fundraising environment in 2027. The DAWG budget is the second. The \$54.6 billion fiscal year 2027 request is an ambition, not an appropriation, and roughly 98% depends on a reconciliation bill that may not pass. The marketplace mechanisms are bankable today. The budget headline is not. Investors who model returns on \$54.6 billion without weighting enactment risk are mispricing defense robotics. The logistics reversal is the third. One quarter of growth after two years of decline is not a trend. Last-mile delivery is carrying the recovery while AMRs and AGVs keep declining in YoY value. The FAA BVLOS rule should add a tailwind in H2 2026, but the recovery needs another quarter to confirm.

Segment outlook: Three segments are accelerating. Defense & security has operational procurement rails and structural demand across UAS (\$9 billion TTM) and maritime (\$2.1 billion TTM), with the unappropriated DAWG budget the main risk. Industrial robotics is close behind, led by assembly and manufacturing at \$7.8 billion TTM, up 385% YoY, with deployment proof expanding, although the humanoid demo-to-deployment gap and the China-volume-versus-West-revenue question hang over it. Robotics software & AI completes the group: AI autonomy platforms at \$5.3 billion TTM, up 431%, with orchestration validated at the prime level, held back mainly by generalization that is not yet GPT-3 reliable.

Two segments are stable. Medical and healthcare holds on surgical robotics (\$1 billion TTM, up 64%) and diagnostic imaging (\$322 million, up 362%), although hospital logistics stays thin and quarterly value is flat YoY. Robotics hardware & components is steady on end effectors (\$430 million TTM, up 1,035%) and sensors and vision (\$1.3 billion TTM), but actuators are declining in value even as deal count doubles, and power systems are commoditizing.

Two segments are on watch. Logistics & warehousing saw last-mile delivery (\$1.3 billion TTM, up 140%) reverse the segment decline with the BVLOS unlock incoming, but AMRs and AGVs are still contracting. Consumer robotics shows strong subsegment growth in companion & social (\$1.2 billion TTM, up 226%) and entertainment (\$344 million, up 1,148%), offset by a 56% TTM-over-TTM decline that creates unfavorable optics and read-through risk from Unitree's IPO pricing. Agriculture & food is mixed: Food service (\$219 million TTM, up 303%) and crop monitoring are recovering while autonomous farming vehicles and food processing contract against a structurally constrained market.

What to watch in Q2 2026: On the investment data, the central question is whether deal value holds above \$8 billion or normalizes toward \$6 billion. The \$16.3 billion Q1 figure rode three rounds totaling \$5 billion; strip those and the quarter is \$11.3 billion, which puts the structural run rate at \$8 billion to \$11 billion. Below \$6 billion signals a real pullback. Above \$12 billion without identified mega-rounds means the valuation baseline has reset higher. Three stage-level signals sit alongside it: whether venture growth holds above \$4 billion and stays level with late-stage VC after the first-ever tie at \$5.9 billion each, whether seed count holds above 90 after the record 113 in Q1, and whether logistics posts a second straight quarter of growth. It will be interesting to see whether industrial robotics, now within 10% of defense on a TTM basis (\$10.8 billion versus \$11.9 billion) and growing faster, takes the top segment spot by Q3 or Q4.



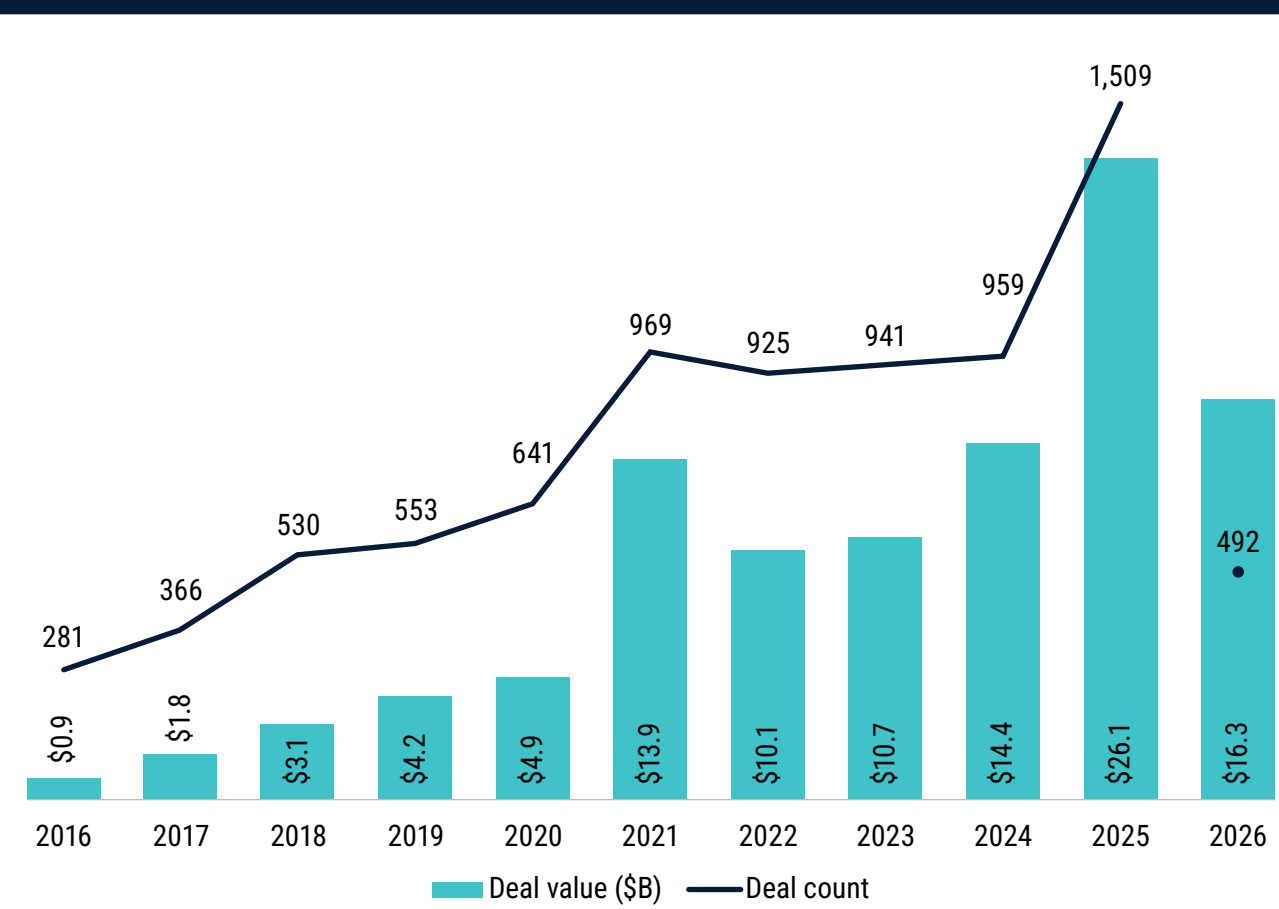
QUARTERLY ANALYSIS

On deployment, four catalysts will move the outlook: whether any humanoid company beyond Agility publishes audited commercial revenue from a paying industrial customer, whether Unitree completes its STAR Market IPO and sets the first public benchmark for a high-volume humanoid manufacturer, whether the DAWG reconciliation bill advances, and whether Physical Intelligence closes its reported \$11 billion-plus round. On market structure, we will be watching to see whether M&A holds above five transactions per quarter after Q1's 14, and whether a new acquirer category appears. Q1 pulled automotive, e-commerce, warehouse automation, infrastructure software, and Japanese consumer electronics into robotics deals. Energy, construction, or healthcare services entering in Q2 would mark a new sector joining the consolidation cycle.



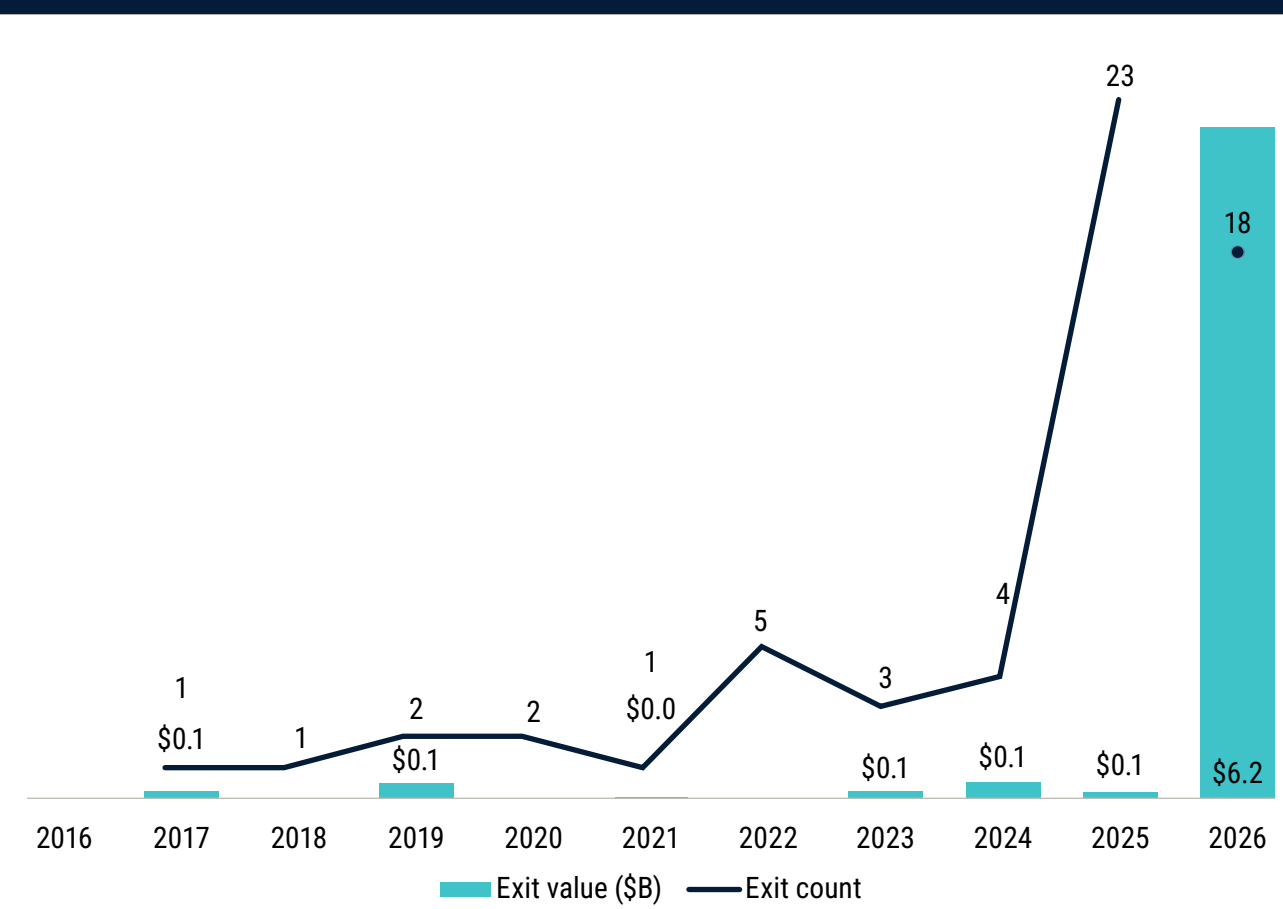
QUARTERLY ANALYSIS

Robotics & physical AI VC deal activity



Source: PitchBook • Geography: Global • As of March 31, 2026

Robotics & physical AI VC exit activity

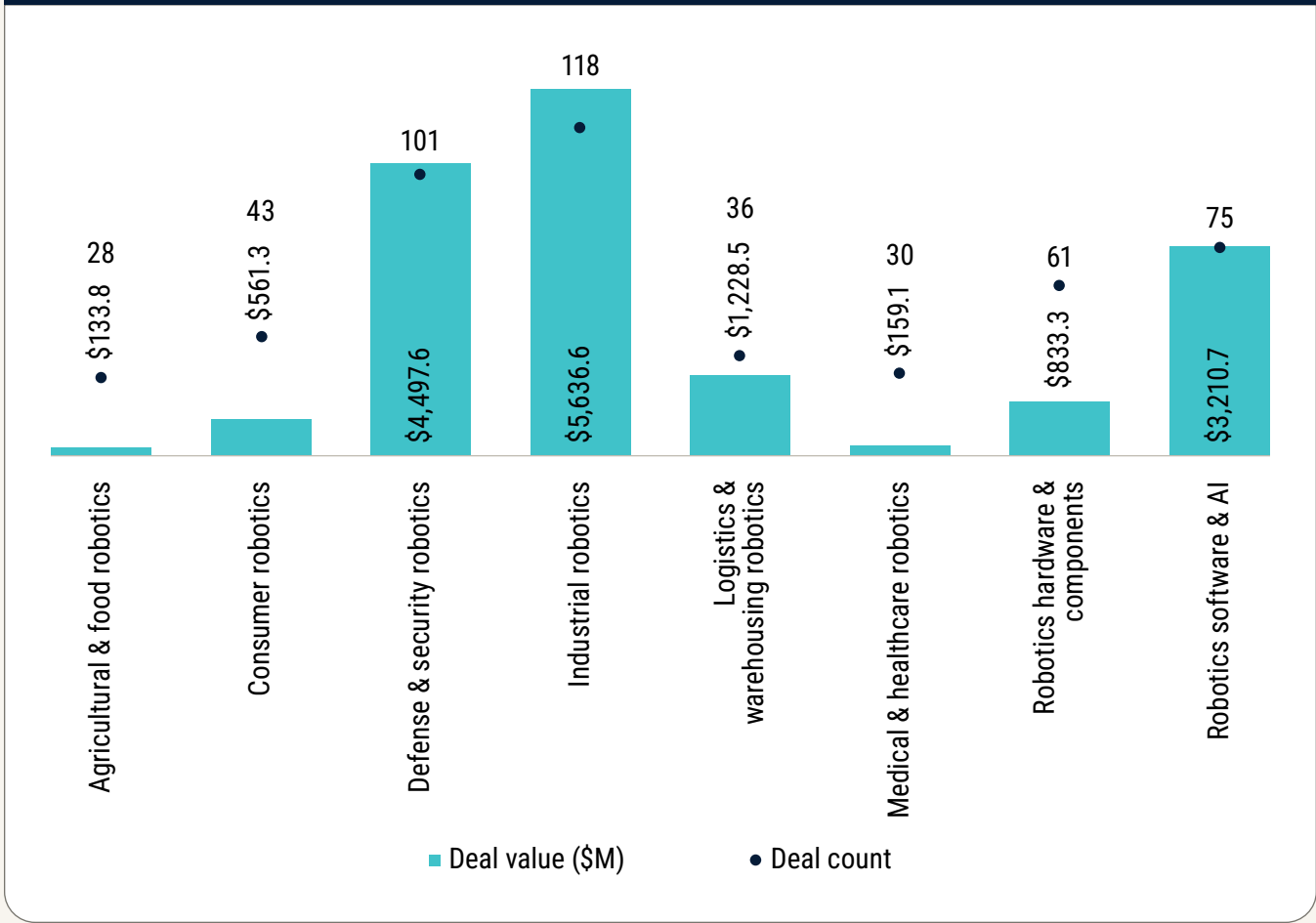


Source: PitchBook • Geography: Global • As of March 31, 2026



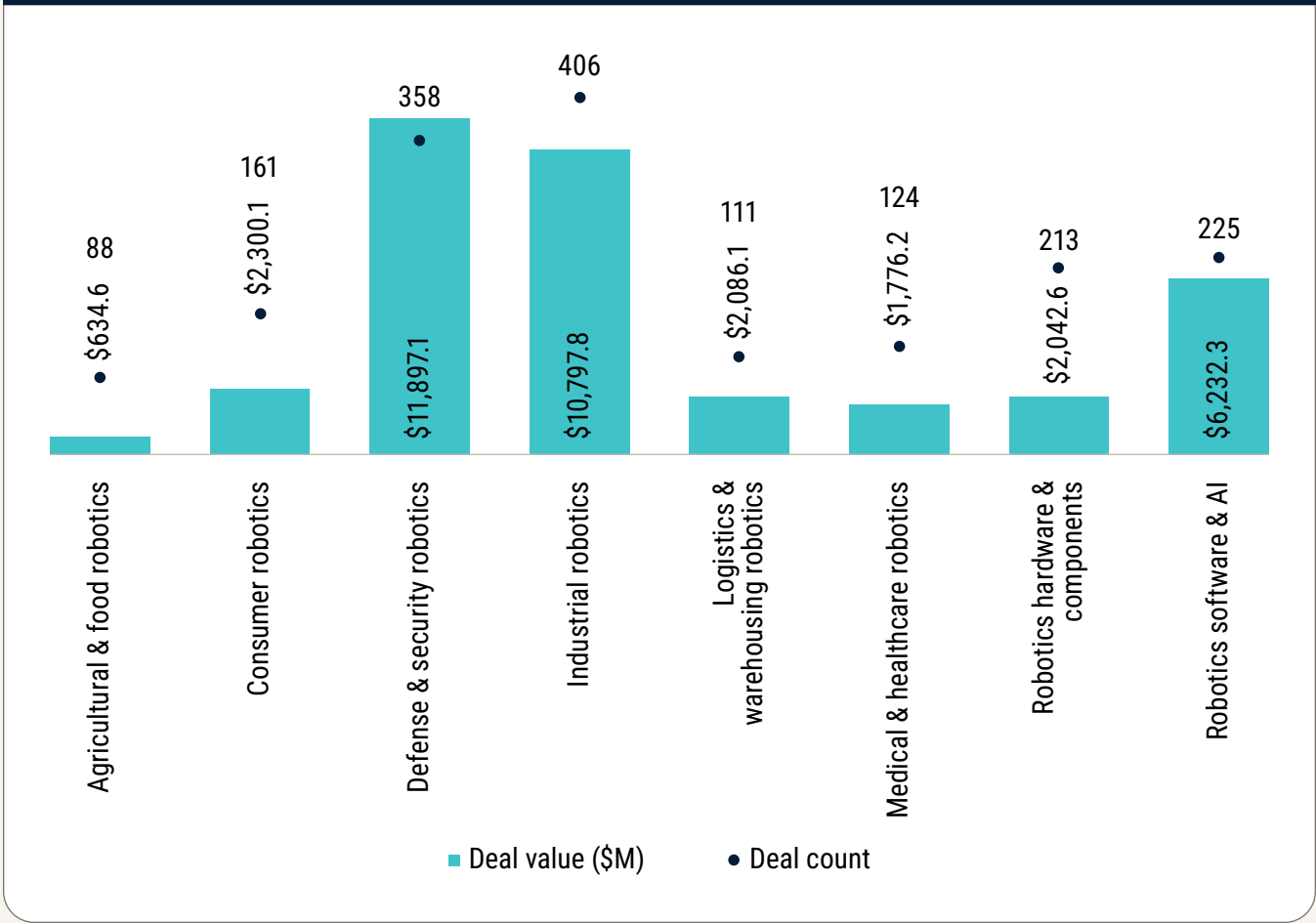
QUARTERLY ANALYSIS

Q1 2026 robotics & physical AI VC deal activity by segment



Source: PitchBook • Geography: Global • As of March 31, 2026

TTM robotics & physical AI VC deal activity by segment

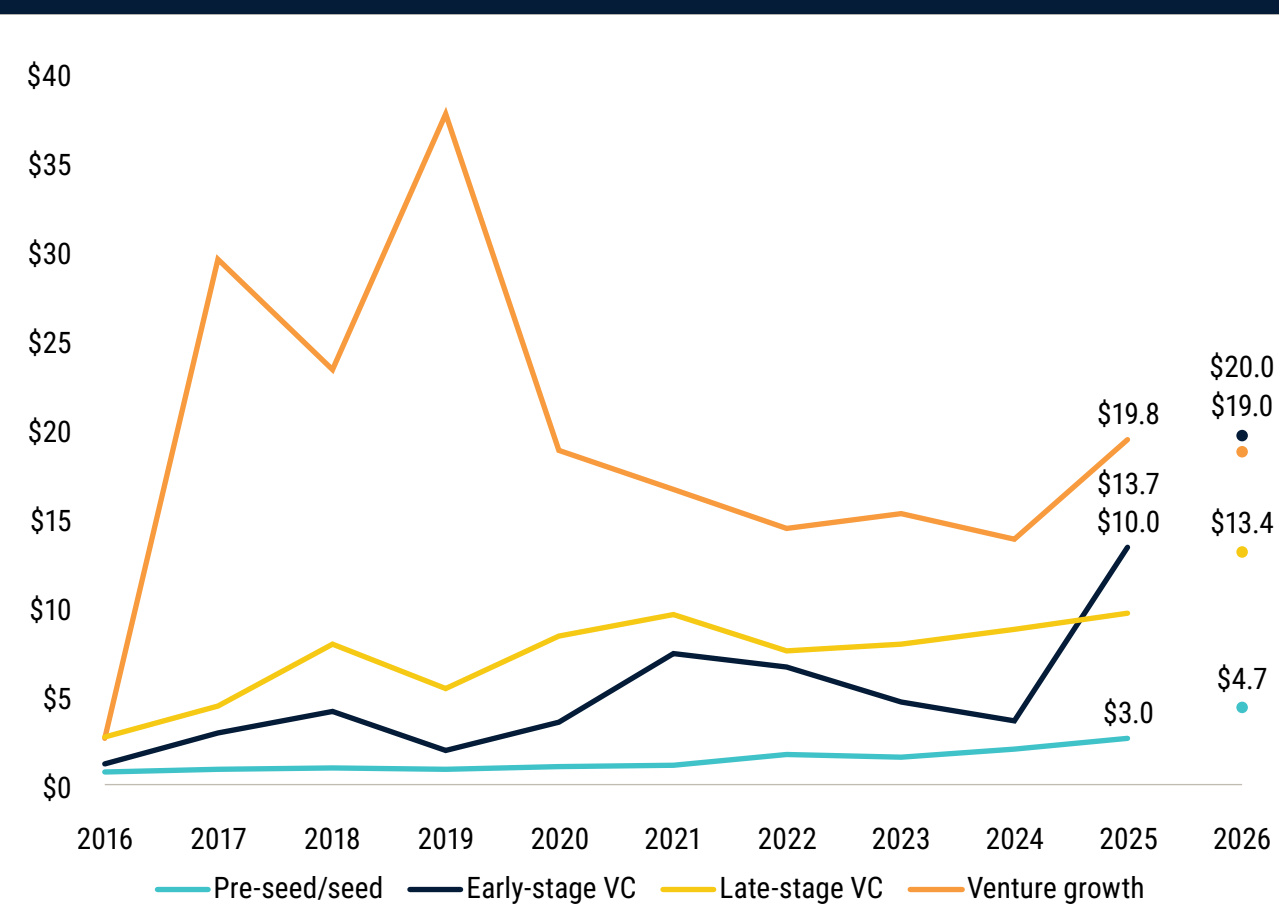


Source: PitchBook • Geography: Global • As of March 31, 2026



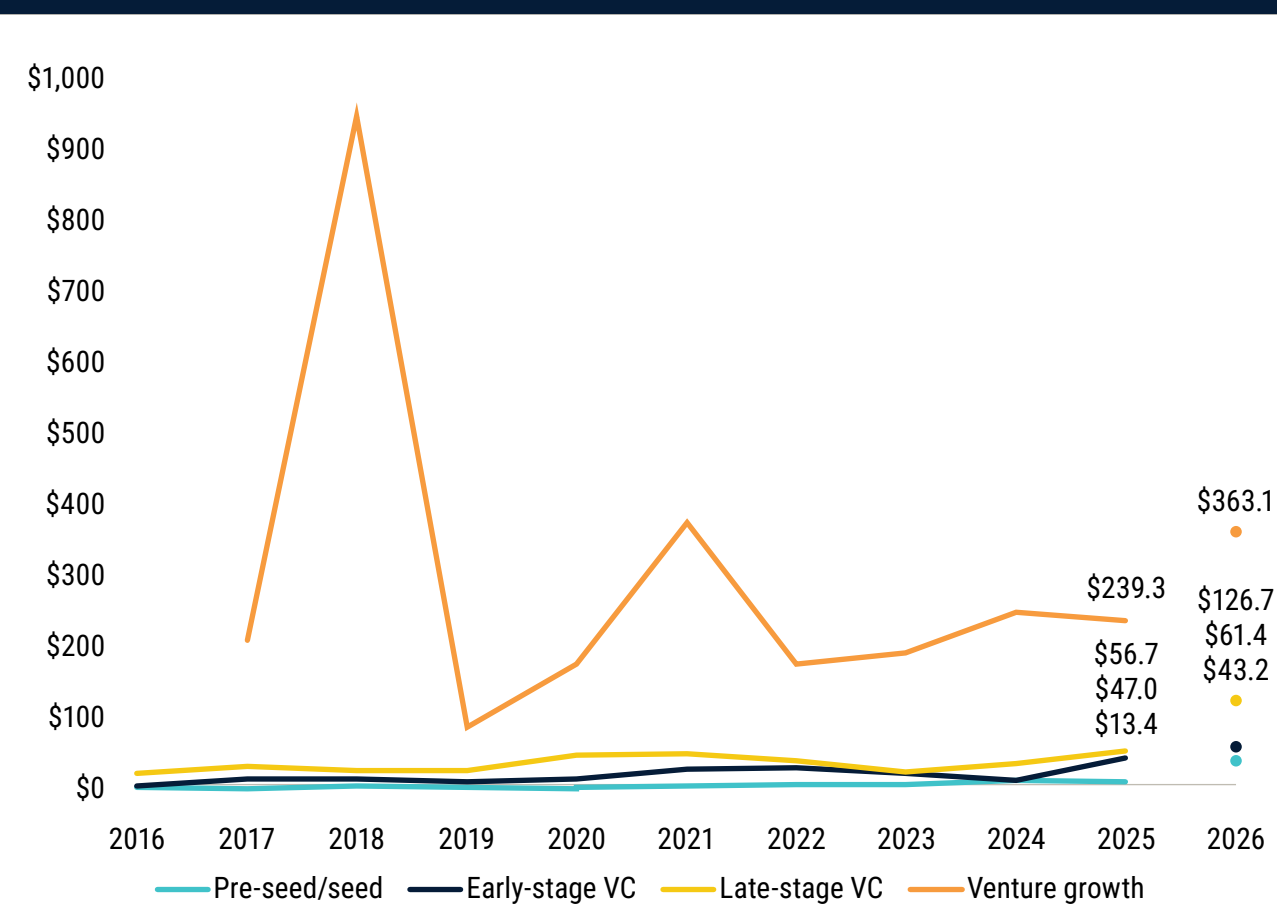
QUARTERLY ANALYSIS

Median robotics & physical AI VC deal value (\$M) by stage



Source: PitchBook • Geography: Global • As of March 31, 2026

Median robotics & physical AI VC pre-money valuation (\$M) by stage



Source: PitchBook • Geography: Global • As of March 31, 2026



QUARTERLY ANALYSIS

Median robotics & physical AI Series A deal value (\$M) by segment

Segment	2016	2017	2018	2019	2020	2021	2022	2023	2024	2025	2026
Agricultural & food robotics	\$2.1	\$3.4	\$4.3	\$8.9	\$10.0	\$6.3	\$5.2	\$7.7	\$6.2	\$9.0	\$10.0
Consumer robotics	\$5.0	\$4.0	\$10.0	\$11.3	\$10.0	\$9.5	\$15.9	\$12.0	\$18.0	\$14.2	\$17.2
Defense & security robotics	\$3.4	\$7.2	\$8.0	\$4.2	\$2.3	\$9.4	\$10.0	\$14.4	\$12.0	\$13.7	\$29.1
Industrial robotics	\$2.2	\$6.0	\$8.0	\$8.1	\$9.1	\$13.0	\$9.1	\$7.5	\$9.1	\$12.0	\$14.5
Logistics & warehousing robotics	\$8.9	\$4.4	\$9.5	\$12.0	\$9.0	\$15.5	\$14.9	\$12.0	\$12.3	\$9.0	\$4.6
Medical & healthcare robotics	\$2.5	\$10.4	\$7.2	\$6.8	\$6.6	\$15.0	\$12.7	\$11.4	\$10.7	\$13.5	\$11.5
Robotics hardware & components	\$12.6	\$8.7	\$8.6	\$7.5	\$6.9	\$6.6	\$12.0	\$8.0	\$8.7	\$13.9	\$15.7
Robotics software & AI	\$9.1	\$5.8	\$10.5	\$5.0	\$4.9	\$9.6	\$7.1	\$9.2	\$13.8	\$13.0	\$81.8

Source: PitchBook • Geography: Global • As of March 31, 2026



QUARTERLY ANALYSIS

Median robotics & physical AI Series A pre-money valuation (\$M) by segment

Segment	2016	2017	2018	2019	2020	2021	2022	2023	2024	2025	2026
Agricultural & food robotics	\$2.2	\$14.8	\$10.0	\$29.1	\$22.0	\$17.1	\$34.1	\$41.1	\$14.6	\$53.0	\$33.0
Consumer robotics	\$38.3	\$46.5	\$60.0	\$31.5	\$30.0	\$264.0	\$64.0	\$91.3	\$82.0	\$91.0	\$52.9
Defense & security robotics	\$13.6	\$18.1	\$22.0	\$35.5	\$10.4	\$29.7	\$30.5	\$40.3	\$36.5	\$64.4	\$152.0
Industrial robotics	\$13.0	\$21.0	\$22.1	\$18.6	\$32.5	\$35.0	\$69.1	\$31.4	\$51.0	\$38.0	\$1,500.0
Logistics & warehousing robotics	\$20.0	\$14.9	\$32.4	\$35.0	\$21.1	\$50.0	\$40.0	\$30.5	\$49.4	\$41.0	\$7.5
Medical & healthcare robotics	\$13.9	\$35.3	\$27.1	\$16.0	\$22.7	\$12.1	\$33.3	\$23.0	\$20.9	\$48.9	\$6.1
Robotics hardware & components	\$0.0	\$17.9	\$16.5	\$37.6	\$24.9	\$15.0	\$42.0	\$16.4	\$20.4	\$56.0	\$507.2
Robotics software & AI	\$24.0	\$14.4	\$24.8	\$16.0	\$18.6	\$40.0	\$44.7	\$60.0	\$50.5	\$58.5	\$201.8

Source: PitchBook • Geography: Global • As of March 31, 2026



QUARTERLY ANALYSIS

Median robotics & physical AI Series B deal value (\$M) by segment

Segment	2016	2017	2018	2019	2020	2021	2022	2023	2024	2025	2026
Agricultural & food robotics	\$6.0	\$37.8	\$10.6	\$13.2	\$17.0	\$26.1	\$15.6	\$17.5	\$15.7	\$25.0	\$8.9
Consumer robotics	\$11.0	\$30.0	\$17.8	\$10.6	\$14.6	\$17.8	\$42.0	\$14.1	\$60.0	\$14.0	\$120.0
Defense & security robotics	\$20.2	\$23.2	\$23.7	\$22.2	\$17.0	\$15.6	\$26.8	\$13.9	\$28.1	\$52.0	\$46.4
Industrial robotics	\$15.3	\$17.2	\$17.9	\$11.6	\$17.0	\$19.6	\$15.7	\$13.9	\$30.4	\$27.3	\$17.2
Logistics & warehousing robotics	\$25.0	\$25.1	\$21.5	\$14.9	\$21.6	\$15.6	\$20.0	\$32.0	\$24.8	\$14.1	\$34.0
Medical & healthcare robotics	\$6.1	\$17.9	\$17.9	\$4.0	\$12.2	\$15.4	\$14.9	\$22.1	\$14.4	\$30.0	\$42.6
Robotics hardware & components	\$5.4	\$15.8	\$15.9	\$8.0	\$17.1	\$15.4	\$17.0	\$14.5	\$21.4	\$13.9	\$35.0
Robotics software & AI	\$0.0	\$15.4	\$0.0	\$105.5	\$22.1	\$15.5	\$19.4	\$14.6	\$23.6	\$41.6	\$100.0

Source: PitchBook • Geography: Global • As of March 31, 2026



QUARTERLY ANALYSIS

Median robotics & physical AI Series B pre-money valuation (\$M) by segment

Segment	2016	2017	2018	2019	2020	2021	2022	2023	2024	2025	2026
Agricultural & food robotics	\$0.0	\$143.9	\$18.1	\$40.0	\$45.0	\$52.0	\$60.6	\$67.2	\$82.3	\$145.3	\$0.0
Consumer robotics	\$0.0	\$170.0	\$24.4	\$130.0	\$40.0	\$48.2	\$60.0	\$81.3	\$206.9	\$31.6	\$1,302.6
Defense & security robotics	\$109.6	\$65.0	\$93.2	\$130.0	\$70.0	\$95.0	\$86.6	\$107.7	\$47.0	\$723.0	\$347.2
Industrial robotics	\$53.9	\$72.8	\$111.4	\$58.3	\$59.5	\$157.0	\$153.0	\$117.1	\$140.0	\$84.5	\$100.2
Logistics & warehousing robotics	\$195.0	\$85.0	\$57.5	\$32.5	\$92.8	\$74.1	\$204.5	\$100.0	\$77.6	\$50.0	\$182.0
Medical & healthcare robotics	\$36.5	\$33.6	\$26.6	\$25.0	\$50.9	\$239.7	\$77.3	\$75.6	\$93.5	\$105.5	\$0.0
Robotics hardware & components	\$13.9	\$59.1	\$0.0	\$23.0	\$74.9	\$213.8	\$101.0	\$111.9	\$194.0	\$72.4	\$422.0
Robotics software & AI	\$0.0	\$0.0	\$0.0	\$1,400.0	\$81.8	\$102.0	\$137.5	\$115.1	\$178.0	\$400.0	\$655.5

Source: PitchBook • Geography: Global • As of March 31, 2026



QUARTERLY ANALYSIS

Median robotics & physical AI Series C deal value (\$M) by segment

Segment	2016	2017	2018	2019	2020	2021	2022	2023	2024	2025	2026
Agricultural & food robotics	\$0.0	\$0.0	\$0.0	\$0.0	\$41.5	\$40.0	\$0.0	\$18.0	\$44.5	\$0.0	\$18.0
Consumer robotics	\$0.0	\$0.0	\$26.7	\$28.1	\$30.0	\$145.4	\$17.9	\$0.0	\$39.9	\$96.4	\$0.0
Defense & security robotics	\$0.0	\$30.2	\$17.6	\$28.4	\$123.5	\$72.0	\$55.6	\$6.9	\$155.9	\$68.0	\$2.1
Industrial robotics	\$0.0	\$0.0	\$14.6	\$10.0	\$14.3	\$35.1	\$31.3	\$24.9	\$91.1	\$281.4	\$112.0
Logistics & warehousing robotics	\$0.0	\$0.0	\$70.0	\$83.1	\$90.6	\$50.0	\$70.0	\$38.1	\$62.2	\$107.5	\$25.8
Medical & healthcare robotics	\$0.0	\$15.0	\$18.8	\$36.2	\$14.7	\$47.4	\$29.8	\$42.0	\$57.6	\$36.9	\$0.0
Robotics hardware & components	\$0.0	\$0.0	\$0.8	\$0.0	\$49.3	\$28.3	\$31.0	\$0.0	\$98.5	\$14.0	\$30.0
Robotics software & AI	\$0.0	\$114.0	\$0.0	\$0.0	\$50.0	\$39.0	\$61.7	\$84.2	\$34.8	\$22.3	\$730.0

Source: PitchBook • Geography: Global • As of March 31, 2026



QUARTERLY ANALYSIS

Median robotics & physical AI Series C pre-money valuation (\$M) by segment

Segment	2016	2017	2018	2019	2020	2021	2022	2023	2024	2025	2026
Agricultural & food robotics	\$0.0	\$0.0	\$0.0	\$0.0	\$540.0	\$20.9	\$0.0	\$93.8	\$136.3	\$0.0	\$0.0
Consumer robotics	\$0.0	\$0.0	\$323.0	\$182.9	\$193.4	\$1,406.8	\$153.2	\$0.0	\$491.2	\$1,666.2	\$0.0
Defense & security robotics	\$0.0	\$0.0	\$109.9	\$0.0	\$977.5	\$230.0	\$594.0	\$819.8	\$102.9	\$906.7	\$17.0
Industrial robotics	\$0.0	\$0.0	\$138.4	\$90.0	\$134.4	\$420.2	\$300.0	\$247.2	\$460.0	\$1,750.0	\$1,155.4
Logistics & warehousing robotics	\$0.0	\$0.0	\$550.0	\$158.0	\$374.3	\$231.7	\$252.5	\$196.2	\$212.2	\$112.0	\$362.1
Medical & healthcare robotics	\$0.0	\$35.0	\$110.3	\$605.5	\$94.5	\$127.7	\$0.0	\$180.0	\$0.0	\$62.0	\$0.0
Robotics hardware & components	\$0.0	\$0.0	\$0.0	\$0.0	\$0.0	\$96.3	\$238.0	\$0.0	\$286.1	\$215.9	\$594.6
Robotics software & AI	\$0.0	\$0.0	\$0.0	\$0.0	\$0.0	\$312.1	\$160.4	\$834.9	\$790.2	\$323.7	\$12,600.0

Source: PitchBook • Geography: Global • As of March 31, 2026



QUARTERLY ANALYSIS

Median robotics & physical AI Series D+ deal value (\$M) by segment

Segment	2016	2017	2018	2019	2020	2021	2022	2023	2024	2025	2026
Agricultural & food robotics	\$0.0	\$0.0	\$0.0	\$0.0	\$0.0	\$120.0	\$11.7	\$0.0	\$35.3	\$63.2	\$0.0
Consumer robotics	\$0.0	\$23.8	\$0.0	\$0.0	\$0.0	\$90.9	\$0.0	\$0.0	\$0.0	\$55.0	\$0.0
Defense & security robotics	\$0.0	\$0.0	\$0.0	\$0.0	\$38.5	\$210.0	\$98.6	\$290.3	\$850.0	\$244.9	\$1,625.0
Industrial robotics	\$0.0	\$36.0	\$0.0	\$35.0	\$0.0	\$33.1	\$30.0	\$0.0	\$107.0	\$19.3	\$76.2
Logistics & warehousing robotics	\$0.0	\$0.0	\$0.0	\$190.0	\$45.9	\$200.0	\$225.0	\$232.5	\$46.0	\$0.0	\$800.0
Medical & healthcare robotics	\$0.0	\$0.0	\$0.0	\$0.0	\$65.0	\$348.4	\$52.7	\$29.1	\$69.0	\$50.4	\$0.0
Robotics hardware & components	\$0.0	\$0.0	\$0.0	\$0.0	\$0.0	\$0.0	\$38.0	\$14.4	\$0.0	\$25.1	\$0.0
Robotics software & AI	\$0.0	\$0.0	\$0.0	\$0.0	\$36.2	\$600.0	\$0.0	\$33.7	\$32.0	\$200.0	\$102.7

Source: PitchBook • Geography: Global • As of March 31, 2026



QUARTERLY ANALYSIS

Median robotics & physical AI Series D+ pre-money valuation (\$M) by segment

Segment	2016	2017	2018	2019	2020	2021	2022	2023	2024	2025	2026
Agricultural & food robotics	\$0.0	\$0.0	\$0.0	\$0.0	\$0.0	\$641.5	\$0.0	\$0.0	\$158.1	\$392.9	\$0.0
Consumer robotics	\$0.0	\$165.9	\$0.0	\$0.0	\$0.0	\$548.8	\$0.0	\$0.0	\$0.0	\$0.0	\$0.0
Defense & security robotics	\$0.0	\$0.0	\$0.0	\$0.0	\$277.1	\$1,300.0	\$2,150.0	\$4,000.0	\$8,550.0	\$6,142.5	\$9,475.0
Industrial robotics	\$0.0	\$259.0	\$0.0	\$201.6	\$0.0	\$379.4	\$249.1	\$0.0	\$1,020.0	\$400.8	\$1,298.9
Logistics & warehousing robotics	\$0.0	\$0.0	\$0.0	\$1,200.0	\$315.0	\$1,743.0	\$1,769.0	\$3,870.0	\$318.0	\$0.0	\$6,800.0
Medical & healthcare robotics	\$0.0	\$0.0	\$0.0	\$0.0	\$220.0	\$1,102.9	\$130.0	\$1,117.9	\$251.8	\$249.7	\$0.0
Robotics hardware & components	\$0.0	\$0.0	\$0.0	\$0.0	\$0.0	\$0.0	\$820.0	\$16.7	\$0.0	\$105.4	\$0.0
Robotics software & AI	\$0.0	\$0.0	\$0.0	\$0.0	\$499.3	\$8,000.0	\$0.0	\$463.3	\$633.0	\$5,800.0	\$117.9

Source: PitchBook • Geography: Global • As of March 31, 2026



QUARTERLY ANALYSIS

Share of companies founded 2015 to 2020 that reached a \$250 million valuation by segment

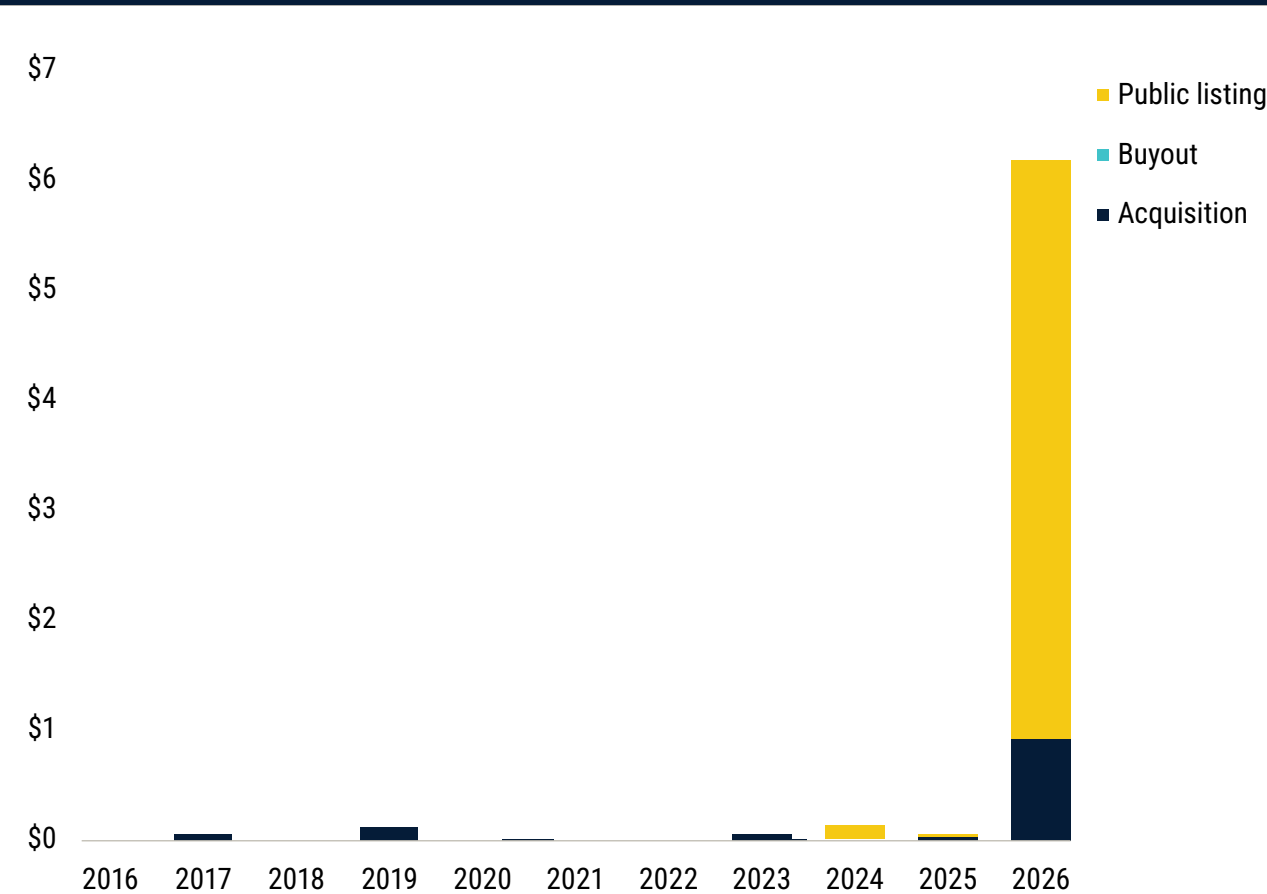
Segment	Below \$250M	Above \$250M	% Share
Agricultural & food robotics	217	4	1.8%
Consumer robotics	223	12	5.1%
Defense & security robotics	480	32	6.3%
Industrial robotics	554	33	5.6%
Logistics & warehousing robotics	229	18	7.3%
Medical & healthcare robotics	239	12	4.8%
Robotics hardware & components	287	12	4.0%
Robotics software & AI	345	21	5.7%

Source: PitchBook • Geography: Global • As of March 31, 2026



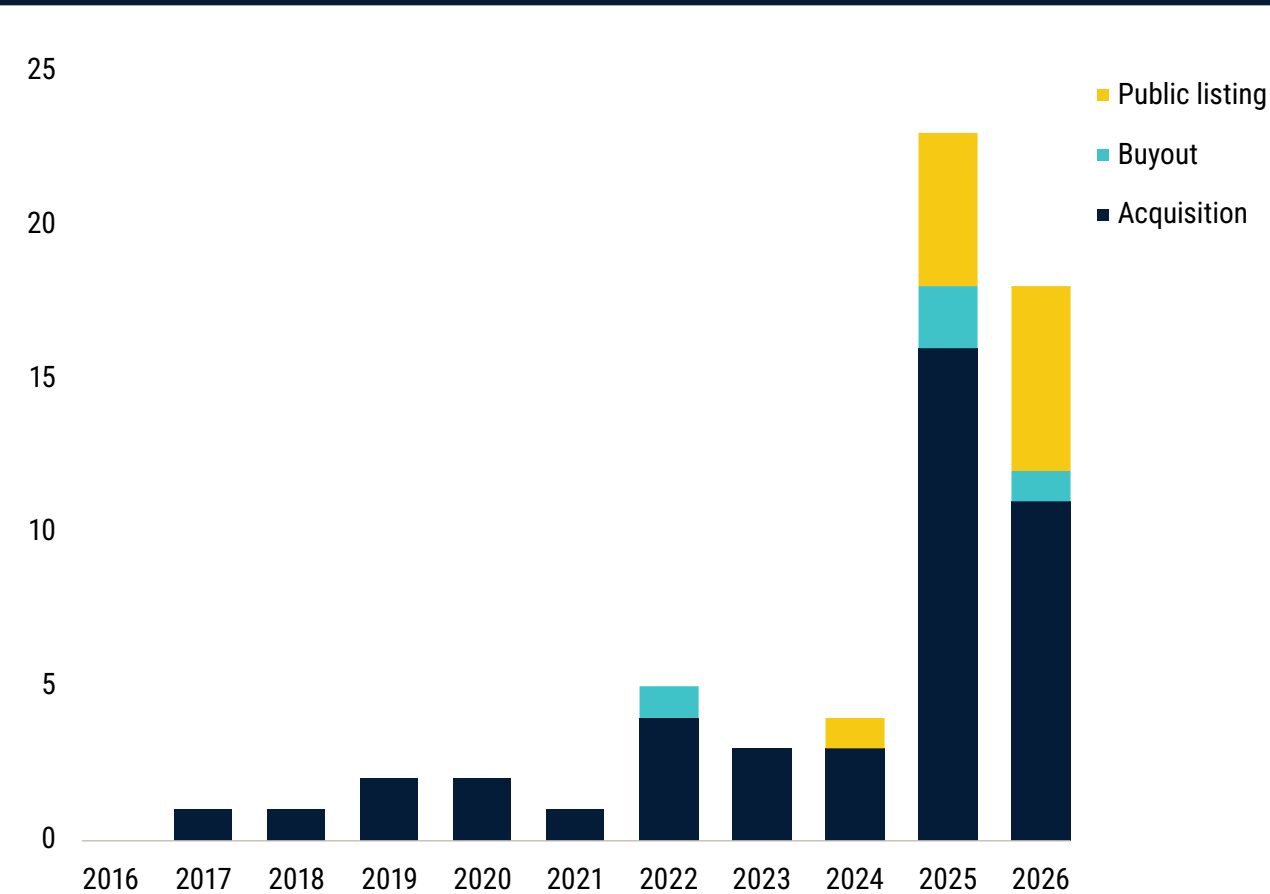
QUARTERLY ANALYSIS

Robotics & physical AI VC exit value (\$B) by type



Source: PitchBook • Geography: Global • As of March 31, 2026

Robotics & physical AI VC exit count by type



Source: PitchBook • Geography: Global • As of March 31, 2026



QUARTERLY ANALYSIS

Robotics & physical AI heatmap by segment

Segment	TTM total deal value (\$M)	TTM total deal count	YoY deal value growth	YoY deal count growth
Agricultural & food robotics	\$634.6	88	20.0%	22.2%
Consumer robotics	\$2,300.1	161	258.3%	64.3%
Defense & security robotics	\$11,897.1	358	119.9%	74.6%
Industrial robotics	\$10,797.8	406	243.3%	107.1%
Logistics & warehousing robotics	\$2,086.1	111	22.7%	8.8%
Medical & healthcare robotics	\$1,776.2	124	71.0%	25.3%
Robotics hardware & components	\$2,042.6	213	24.4%	63.8%
Robotics software & AI	\$6,232.3	225	351.5%	84.4%

Source: PitchBook • Geography: Global • As of March 31, 2026



QUARTERLY ANALYSIS

Robotics & physical AI heatmap by subsegment

Segment	Subsegment	TTM total deal value (\$M)	TTM total deal count	YoY deal value growth	YoY deal count growth
Agricultural & food robotics	Autonomous farming vehicles & drones	\$278.8	40	-20.6%	5.3%
	Crop monitoring & analysis robots	\$85.3	14	34.5%	-12.5%
	Food processing & packaging robots	\$51.3	3	-14.5%	0.0%
	Food service robots	\$219.3	31	303.4%	106.7%
Consumer robotics	Companion & social robots	\$1,167.0	66	225.8%	29.4%
	Domestic service robots	\$788.9	64	207.9%	82.9%
	Entertainment & hobby robotics	\$344.2	30	1,147.6%	150.0%
Defense & security robotics	Security & patrol robots	\$229.2	48	-62.8%	242.9%
	Unmanned aerial systems	\$9,016.8	237	141.5%	64.6%
	Unmanned ground vehicles	\$509.5	17	245.9%	0.0%
	Unmanned maritime systems	\$2,141.6	56	134.7%	86.7%
Industrial robotics	Assembly & manufacturing robots	\$7,799.4	237	384.7%	169.3%
	Hazardous environment robots	\$730.5	82	231.6%	82.2%
	Inspection & quality control robots	\$862.0	75	-24.0%	47.1%
	Material handling & palletizing	\$1,405.9	12	673.7%	0.0%

Source: PitchBook • Geography: Global • As of March 31, 2026



QUARTERLY ANALYSIS

Robotics & physical AI heatmap by subsegment (continued)

Segment	Subsegment	TTM total deal value (\$M)	TTM total deal count	YoY deal value growth	YoY deal count growth
Logistics & warehousing robotics	Automated guided vehicles	\$52.3	17	-50.8%	88.9%
	Autonomous mobile robots	\$506.2	36	-16.6%	-25.0%
	Last-mile delivery robots & drones	\$1,327.1	39	140.0%	39.3%
	Sorting & packaging robots	\$200.5	19	-53.9%	11.8%
Medical & healthcare robotics	Diagnostic & imaging robotics	\$322.2	18	362.2%	12.5%
	Hospital logistics robots	\$86.2	9	149.7%	12.5%
	Rehabilitation & assistive robots	\$319.8	38	8.3%	18.8%
	Surgical robotics	\$1,048.1	59	64.0%	37.2%
Robotics hardware & components	Actuators & motion systems	\$108.7	58	-19.2%	100.0%
	End effectors & tooling	\$429.9	30	1,034.8%	275.0%
	Power & energy systems	\$236.6	25	-47.0%	-16.7%
	Sensors & vision systems	\$1,267.4	100	23.9%	58.7%
Robotics software & AI	AI & autonomy platforms	\$5,299.8	129	431.2%	126.3%
	Computer vision & perception	\$239.4	26	136.5%	23.8%
	Path planning & navigation	\$170.4	17	7.0%	30.8%
	Robot operating systems & middleware	\$522.7	53	327.7%	71.0%

Source: PitchBook • Geography: Global • As of March 31, 2026



QUARTERLY ANALYSIS

Key robotics & physical AI pre-seed VC deals in Q1 2026

Company	Close date	Deal value (\$M)	Post-money valuation (\$M)	Segment	Subsegment	Lead investor(s)
Breaking Shell Intelligence	March 29	\$58.0	N/A	Consumer robotics	Domestic service robots	N/A
UFORCE	March 5	\$50.0	\$1,000.0	Defense & security robotics	Unmanned aerial systems	Lakestar, Shield Capital
RLWRLD	February 25	\$40.8	N/A	Robotics software & AI	AI & autonomy platforms	Hashed, Headline, Z Venture Capital
Humble Robotics	March 13	\$24.0	N/A	Logistics & warehousing robotics	Autonomous mobile robots	Eclipse Capital
Foundry Robotics	February 6	\$19.0	\$110.0	Industrial robotics	Assembly & manufacturing robots	Khosla Ventures
Haply Robotics	January 30	\$11.6	N/A	Medical & healthcare robotics	Surgical robotics	Sound Media Ventures
EGI Battery	March 4	\$10.0	N/A	Robotics hardware & components	Power & energy systems	TSV Capital (Los Altos)
MightyFly	February 12	\$10.0	N/A	Logistics & warehousing robotics	Last-mile delivery robots & drones	N/A
Ropedia	March 16	\$10.0	N/A	Robotics software & AI	AI & autonomy platforms	N/A
HYPRLABS	February 4	\$9.5	\$70.7	Robotics software & AI	AI & autonomy platforms	N/A

Source: PitchBook • Geography: Global • As of March 31, 2026



QUARTERLY ANALYSIS

Key robotics & physical AI early-stage VC deals in Q1 2026

Company	Close date	Deal value (\$M)	Post-money valuation (\$M)	Segment	Subsegment	Lead investor(s)
Mind Robotics	March 11	\$500.0	\$2,000.0	Industrial robotics	Assembly & manufacturing robots	Accel, Andreessen Horowitz
Rhoda AI	March 6	\$450.0	\$1,700.0	Robotics software & AI	AI & autonomy platforms	Capricorn Investment Group, Khosla Ventures, Mayfield Fund, Premji Invest, Temasek Holdings
Spirit AI Robotics	February 24	\$288.6	\$1,443.2	Industrial robotics	Assembly & manufacturing robots	Chaos Investment, HSG (Hong Kong), Yunfeng Capital
Linkerbot	February 12	\$215.7	N/A	Robotics hardware & components	End effectors & tooling	Beijing Shengshi Hongming Investment Fund Management, Daode Investment
LightWheel AI	March 11	\$145.0	N/A	Robotics software & AI	AI & autonomy platforms	N/A
PaXini Tech	March 5	\$144.8	\$1,447.7	Robotics hardware & components	Sensors & vision systems	HPR Capital, Kaitai Capital, Quzhou State-owned Assets Supervision and Administration Commission Information Security Management
Robotera	March 4	\$144.7	\$1,447.3	Consumer robotics	Companion & social robots	N/A
Noetix	March 2	\$144.6	N/A	Defense & security robotics	Unmanned aerial systems	Chendao Capital
AI2 Robotics	February 23	\$144.3	\$1,442.7	Robotics software & AI	AI & autonomy platforms	N/A
Galaxea AI	February 11	\$143.8	N/A	Industrial robotics	Inspection & quality control robots	Jinding Capital

Source: PitchBook • Geography: Global • As of March 31, 2026



QUARTERLY ANALYSIS

Key robotics & physical AI late-stage VC deals in Q1 2026

Company	Close date	Deal value (\$M)	Post-money valuation (\$M)	Segment	Subsegment	Lead investor(s)	Valuation step-up (post to pre)
Saronic	March 27	\$1,750.0	\$9,250.0	Defense & security robotics	Unmanned maritime systems	Kleiner Perkins	1.9x
Skild AI	January 14	\$1,400.0	\$14,000.0	Robotics software & AI	AI & autonomy platforms	Nvidia, SoftBank Group	2.7x
Hadrian	January 9	\$391.3	\$1,600.0	Industrial robotics	Assembly & manufacturing robots	T. Rowe Price Group	2.0x
GalBot	March 2	\$361.6	N/A	Industrial robotics	Assembly & manufacturing robots	N/A	N/A
Performance Drone Works	March 25	\$162.4	N/A	Defense & security robotics	Unmanned aerial systems	Ondas	N/A
Mytra	January 15	\$140.0	\$565.0	Logistics & warehousing robotics	Autonomous mobile robots	Avenir Growth Capital	2.2x
SmartMore	February 11	\$127.8	\$1,230.0	Industrial robotics	Assembly & manufacturing robots	N/A	1.0x
Machina Labs	February 4	\$124.0	\$374.0	Industrial robotics	Assembly & manufacturing robots	N/A	2.7x
Gecko Robotics	January 5	\$123.4	\$1,647.0	Industrial robotics	Inspection & quality control robots	Cox Enterprises	2.4x
Advanced Navigation	March 17	\$111.6	\$706.2	Robotics hardware & components	Sensors & vision systems	Airtree Ventures	1.9x

Source: PitchBook • Geography: Global • As of March 31, 2026



QUARTERLY ANALYSIS

Key robotics & physical AI venture-growth deals in Q1 2026

Company	Close date	Deal value (\$M)	Post-money valuation (\$M)	Segment	Subsegment	Lead investor(s)	Valuation step-up (post to pre)
Neura Robotics	March 1	\$1,774.9	\$5,916.2	Industrial robotics	Assembly & manufacturing robots	N/A	N/A
Shield AI	March 26	\$1,500.0	\$12,700.0	Defense & security robotics	Unmanned aerial systems	Advent International, JP Morgan Chase, The Resiliency Initiative	2.2x
Apptronik	February 11	\$935.0	\$5,300.0	Industrial robotics	Material handling & palletizing	B Capital Group, Capital Factory	N/A
Zipline	March 23	\$800.0	\$7,600.0	Logistics & warehousing robotics	Last-mile delivery robots & drones	Fidelity Management & Research Company	1.3x
Aerofugia	January 26	\$143.1	N/A	Defense & security robotics	Unmanned aerial systems	China Securities	N/A
Oxa Autonomy	March 4	\$105.4	\$223.3	Robotics software & AI	AI & autonomy platforms	National Wealth Fund (United Kingdom)	N/A
QCraft	March 23	\$100.0	N/A	Robotics software & AI	AI & autonomy platforms	N/A	N/A
Boonray	January 28	\$92.5	\$378.9	Robotics software & AI	AI & autonomy platforms	N/A	1.3x
Realman	March 4	\$72.4	N/A	Industrial robotics	Assembly & manufacturing robots	N/A	N/A
Hitbot	March 31	\$34.8	N/A	Industrial robotics	Assembly & manufacturing robots	N/A	N/A

Source: PitchBook • Geography: Global • As of March 31, 2026



QUARTERLY ANALYSIS

Key robotics & physical AI VC exits in Q1 2026

Company	Close date	Deal value (\$M)	Post-money valuation (\$M)	Exit type consolidated	Segment	Subsegment	Acquirers(s)
Shenzhen Edge Medical	January 8	\$2,000.1	\$2,177.3	Public listing	Medical & healthcare robotics	Surgical robotics	Abu Dhabi Investment Authority, China Alpha Fund Management, China Asset Management (Hong Kong), Harbourview Investment, Infini Capital Management, Integrated Core Strategies, Jifeng Ventures, Sage Partners, Tencent Holdings, UBS Group
Huayan Robotics	March 30	\$979.0	\$1,180.8	Public listing	Industrial robotics	Assembly & manufacturing robots	GF Fund Management, Hillhouse Investment Group, Morgan Stanley, Ningbo Meishan Free Trade Port Haojun Investment Management, RICHFIRM (HONG KONG) DEVELOPMENT, Samson Group (Other Commercial Products)
Mentee Robotics	February 6	\$900.0	\$900.0	Acquisition	Logistics & warehousing robotics	Sorting & packaging robots	Mobileye Global
Galaxis Technology	March 24	\$832.6	\$911.0	Public listing	Defense & security robotics	Unmanned aerial systems	N/A
Merlin Labs	March 16	\$800.0	N/A	Public listing	Defense & security robotics	Unmanned aerial systems	Inflection Point Acquisition IV
Isvision Technology	February 11	\$603.3	\$804.3	Public listing	Robotics hardware & components	Sensors & vision systems	Fosun International, GAC Capital, SAIC Capital China, SDIC Securities, SDIC Securities Investment

Source: PitchBook • Geography: Global • As of March 31, 2026



QUARTERLY ANALYSIS

Key robotics & physical AI VC exits in Q1 2026 (continued)

Company	Close date	Deal value (\$M)	Post-money valuation (\$M)	Exit type consolidated	Segment	Subsegment	Acquirers(s)
Swarmer	March 17	\$46.7	\$61.7	Public listing	Defense & security robotics	Unmanned aerial systems	N/A
Diligent Robotics	January 27	\$29.0	\$29.0	Acquisition	Medical & healthcare robotics	Hospital logistics robots	Serve Robotics
Abelio	March 30	N/A	N/A	Acquisition	Agricultural & food robotics	Crop monitoring & analysis robots	Groupe ISAGRI
RIVR Technologies	March 18	N/A	N/A	Acquisition	Logistics & warehousing robotics	Last-mile delivery robots & drones	Amazon.com

Source: PitchBook • Geography: Global • As of March 31, 2026



QUARTERLY ANALYSIS

Top VC investors in robotics & physical AI companies since 2020

Investor	Total	Pre-seed/seed	Early-stage VC	Late-stage VC	Venture growth	Investor type
HSG	77	10	44	17	6	VC
Gaingels	73	18	14	33	8	VC
SOSV	73	37	18	14	4	VC
Alumni Ventures	71	30	16	24	1	VC
Shenzhen Capital Group	55	1	36	9	9	VC
HAX	54	30	10	11	3	CVC
Lenovo Capital and Incubator Group	50	4	35	10	1	CVC
Shunwei Capital	47	3	27	16	1	VC
Mana Ventures	47	15	14	12	6	VC
GL Ventures	42	7	26	9	0	VC

Source: PitchBook • Geography: Global • As of March 31, 2026



QUARTERLY ANALYSIS

Top VC-backed robotics & physical AI companies by total VC raised to date

Company	VC raised to date (\$M)	Segment	Subsegment	Location	Success probability	IPO probability	M&A probability
Anduril Industries	\$6,870.1	Defense & security robotics	Unmanned aerial systems	Costa Mesa, US	98%	97%	1%
Shield AI	\$2,810.3	Defense & security robotics	Unmanned aerial systems	San Diego, US	98%	92%	6%
Saronic	\$2,594.5	Defense & security robotics	Unmanned maritime systems	Austin, US	96%	60%	36%
Nuro	\$2,332.0	Robotics software & AI	Robot operating systems & middleware	Mountain View, US	98%	81%	17%
Figure	\$2,245.0	Industrial robotics	Assembly & manufacturing robots	San Jose, US	92%	77%	15%
Skild AI	\$2,200.0	Robotics software & AI	AI & autonomy platforms	Pittsburgh, US	98%	80%	18%
Neura Robotics	\$2,110.8	Industrial robotics	Assembly & manufacturing robots	Metzingen, Germany	98%	71%	27%
Zipline	\$2,033.3	Logistics & warehousing robotics	Last-mile delivery robots & drones	South San Francisco, US	96%	92%	4%
Helsing	\$1,511.4	Defense & security robotics	Unmanned aerial systems	Munich, Germany	98%	70%	28%
CMR Surgical	\$1,416.9	Medical & healthcare robotics	Surgical robotics	Cambridge, UK	98%	74%	24%

Source: PitchBook • Geography: Global • As of March 31, 2026
Note: Probability data is based on [PitchBook VC Exit Predictor methodology](#).



Robotics & physical AI VC deal summary

	Quarterly activity						Trailing 12-month activity	
	Q1 2025	Q2 2025	Q3 2025	Q4 2025	Q1 2026		Q2 2024-Q1 2025	Q2 2025-Q1 2026
Deal count	315	330	415	449	492		1,024	1,686
QoQ change	18.4%	4.8%	25.8%	8.2%	9.6%		N/A	64.6%
Share of total VC	2.7%	3.3%	4.1%	4.3%	4.9%		2.4%	4.2%
Deal value (\$B)	\$4.57	\$9.79	\$5.30	\$6.41	\$16.26		\$15.49	\$37.77
QoQ change	15.8%	114.2%	-45.9%	20.9%	153.6%		N/A	143.9%
Share of total VC	4.9%	5.9%	4.4%	4.9%	4.9%		3.9%	5.0%
Exit count	2	1	11	9	18		6	39
Acquisitions	1	1	6	8	11		4	26
Buyouts	0	0	2	0	1		0	3
Public Listings	1	0	3	1	6		2	10

Source: PitchBook • Geography: Global • As of March 31, 2026



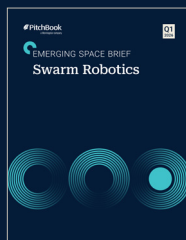
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Nizar Tarhuni

Executive Vice President of Research and Market Intelligence

Paul Condra

Sr. Director, Global Head of Private Markets Research

James Ulan

Director of Emerging Technology Research

Report created by:

Ali Javaheri

Senior Research Analyst, Emerging Spaces

Caleb Wilkins

Data Analyst

Adriana Hansen

Graphic Designer

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